

Recovery Steps and Final Procedure

ChatGPT / Codex Windows recovery, preservation, verification, and restoration

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Purpose. This document records the successful, non-destructive process used to preserve the workspace, repair Windows integrity, install the replacement app build, verify all Codex conversations, and restore the Codex sidebar and project index.

1. Preserve the workspace before changing the app

1. Treat the live project tree as the source of truth:
`C:\CodeProjects`
2. Create and retain two independent preservation copies. The verified copies used were:
`C:\Users\Owner\Desktop\ChatGPT-Codex-Preservation-20260728-101536`
`C:\backupCodeProjects\ChatGPT-Codex-Preservation-20260728-101536`
3. Verify the project copy with Robocopy and accept only a result with zero mismatches and zero failed files. The verified preservation set contained 262,592 files and 13,410,709,947 bytes. The temporary `.tmp.driveupload` directory was intentionally excluded.
4. Request a ChatGPT data export and keep both the downloaded archive and the extracted copy. The extracted export was stored at:
`C:\CodeProjects\Export`

2. Remove the failed installation without touching project data

5. Uninstall the Microsoft Store package and verify that Winget no longer reports it as installed.
6. Uninstall the global Codex CLI package separately:
`npm.cmd uninstall -g @openai/codex`
7. Remove obvious Codex setup leftovers and stale backup/cache directories, but do not delete the live workspace or either preservation copy.
8. Do not recursively reset ownership or ACLs across the entire WindowsApps tree. Only repair the WindowsApps root if its ownership was changed.

3. Repair and verify Windows

9. Restore the owner of the WindowsApps root to TrustedInstaller and confirm that no explicit Everyone permission remains on that root.
10. Run DISM health checks from Administrator PowerShell:
`DISM /Online /Cleanup-Image /CheckHealth`
`DISM /Online /Cleanup-Image /ScanHealth`
11. Run System File Checker from Administrator PowerShell:
`sfc.exe /scannow`

12. Run an online disk scan and let it finish even if the ETA fluctuates:

```
chkdsk C: /scan
```

13. Restart Windows and repeat SFC until the final result is:

Windows Resource Protection did not find any integrity violations.

14. The completed CHKDSK result reported no file-system problems and 0 KB in bad sectors. DISM reported no component-store corruption.

4. Identify the recurring SFC repair

15. Review only the newest [SR] entries in CBS.log instead of reading the entire file.

16. The recurring item was the Default-profile OneDrive shortcut:

```
C:\Users\Default\AppData\Roaming\Microsoft\Windows\Start Menu\Programs\OneDrive.lnk
```

17. After SFC restored that shortcut, the next scan completed cleanly. Do not attribute this repair to ChatGPT or Codex without evidence.

5. Install the replacement Microsoft Store build

18. Install the Store product with Winget:

```
winget install --id 9PLM9XGG6VKS --source msstore --exact --accept-source-agreements --accept-package-agreements
```

19. Before launching, verify the installed AppX package version:

```
Get-AppxPackage OpenAI.Codex | Select-Object Name, Version, PackageFullName, InstallLocation
```

20. Confirm that the build is newer than the failed version. The replacement build was 26.721.11231.0; the failed build was 26.721.4979.0.

21. Launch the app and verify basic stability: successful load, clean sign-in/sign-out, and no immediate lifecycle error.

6. Protect the new local Codex state

22. Close Codex fully before copying local state. Use the tray Quit command and confirm no ChatGPT/Codex process remains. End only the specific app process if necessary.

23. Do not overwrite the new .codex directory with the old one. The directory contains version-sensitive databases, caches, installation identifiers, runtime paths, and credentials.

24. Create a small portable backup of the new configuration, excluding temporary and generated trees. The successful backup was:

```
C:\Users\Owner\Desktop\codex-portable-backup-20260729-192515
```

7. Inspect the old .codex snapshot safely

25. Use the clean preserved source:

```
C:\Users\Owner\Desktop\ChatGPT-Codex-Preservation-20260728-101536\UserProfile-Codex\codex
```

26. Inspect only top-level names first. Do not recursively traverse .tmp or plugin caches unless needed.

27. Do not copy auth.json, installation_id, sandbox files, caches, temp directories, model caches, version.json, or old SQLite files into the live installation.
28. The old config.toml only trusted C:\Windows\System32 and was not useful. The old skills and plugins folders contained only system-managed or cached data.
29. Copy the old SQLite database sets to a separate analysis directory and inspect them read-only. The analysis copy used was:
C:\Users\Owner\Desktop\codex-old-db-analysis
30. The old state database contained zero thread rows, zero goals, and zero memories. It was therefore not a viable source for restoring Codex chats.

8. Verify cloud-backed Codex chats and projects

31. Keep the working installation intact and compare the export with chats visible in Codex.
32. The export contained 148 conversations: 145 active and 3 archived, dated June 11 through July 28, 2026.
33. Verify every exported conversation against Codex. Final result: all 148 were accessible, all 98 older conversations were retrieved, all 3 archived conversations were retrieved, zero failed verification, and one newer chat existed beyond the export cutoff.
34. Save the recovery inventory:
C:\CodeProjects\Export\RECOVERY-INVENTORY.md
C:\CodeProjects\Export\recovery-inventory.csv
35. Do not replace the live Codex database when the cloud-backed conversations are already available.

9. Create a post-recovery project snapshot

36. Create a separate post-recovery snapshot without altering the original preservation set or export.
C:\Users\Owner\Desktop\CodeProjects-post-recovery-20260729
37. Monitor the existing Robocopy process and log instead of starting a second copy. The completed snapshot preserved 262,617 files and 12.529 GB with zero mismatches and zero failed files.

10. Restore the Codex sidebar index offline

38. Prepare and dry-run an offline merge package while Codex remains open only for inspection.
39. The dry run recovered 261 preserved threads, 24 workspace roots, 22 combined project-order entries, and 10 pinned threads. SQLite integrity was OK, and current recovery tasks were preserved.
40. Close Codex completely in Task Manager.
41. Run the prepared offline restore script:
C:\CodeProjects\Export\RUN-SIDEBAR-RESTORE.cmd
42. Wait for “Recovery completed successfully,” then press a key to close the window and reopen Codex.
43. Verify the visible sidebar tree, project ordering, pinned threads, workspace roots, and recent tasks.

11. Final verified state

- WindowsApps root owner restored to NT SERVICE\TrustedInstaller.
- No explicit Everyone ACL remained on the WindowsApps root.
- DISM CheckHealth and ScanHealth reported no corruption.
- CHKDSK reported no file-system problems and no bad sectors.
- Final SFC scan reported no integrity violations.
- Replacement app build 26.721.11231.0 launched and remained stable.
- All 148 exported Codex conversations were verified, including archived items.
- The workspace, project roots, thread index, pinned threads, and sidebar were restored.
- The original preservation set, export, old database analysis, and post-recovery snapshot were retained.